

the zoom level. [0] changes your view to what the camera sees, and [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [0] converts your current viewing angle to that of the camera. Considering that you'll be rendering your scene the way the camera sees it, this is tremendously useful.

A more entertaining way to position the camera right is the Camera Fly Mode, accessed when you're in the camera view by pressing [Shift] + [F]. Initially, you'll be free to look around the scene; click in the middle of your view and you'll find that the camera has begun to fly like an aircraft. Repeated clicking makes you fly faster, and hit the Spacebar when you've flown to an angle you like.

That's enough of that, let's start...

Doing Things

When Blender first starts up, you're faced with a cube, a light, and a camera. To select any of these objects, right-click on them. When you've done that, you'll see the red, green, and blue axes at the centre—click on any of these axes and drag the mouse to move the object along that axis. If you don't want to confine yourself to one axis, "grab" the object by pressing [G], and move it around with the mouse. When you're done, left-click to commit your changes.

To rotate the object, hit [R], and if you want to confine this rotation to a particular axis, press [X], [Y], or [Z] while you're in the rotation mode. Scaling objects—[S]—also works this way, simple and logical.

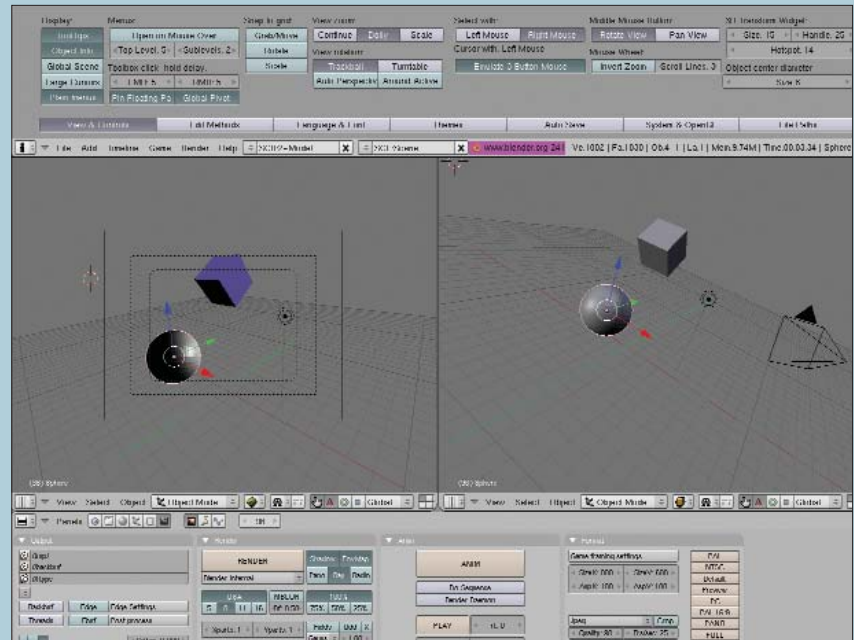
And then, there are the mouse gestures—using the left-click, draw a straight line to grab the selected object, draw a straight line and track back (left-right-left, for example) to scale the object, and draw a curved line to start rotating the object.

Now, on to creating new objects: you can either hold down the left mouse button and wait for the Add menu to pop up, or simply hit the spacebar and select the object you want to add to the scene. When you add a new object, you're automatically

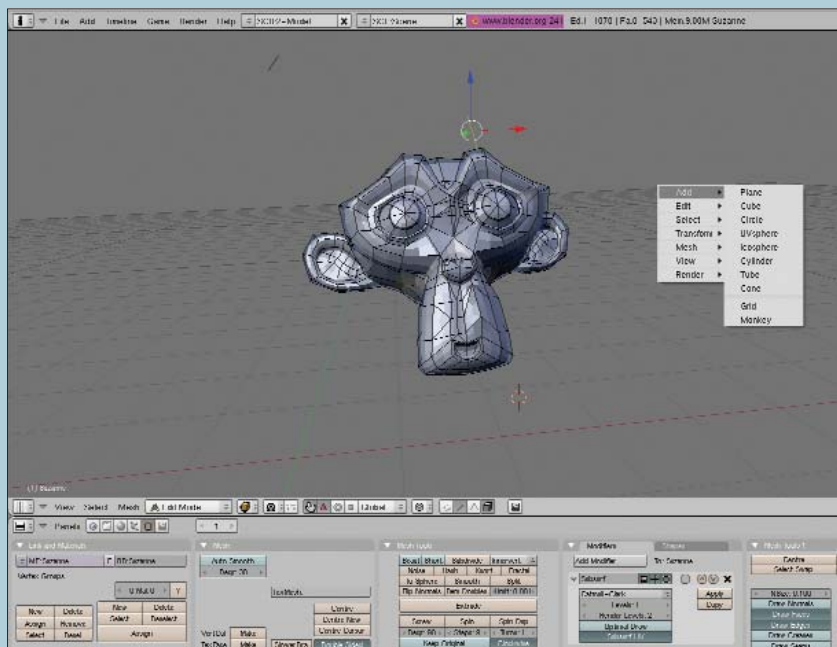
taken to Edit Mode, where you can fine-tune your object by moving its vertices around. You can choose your editing mode—whether you want to edit vertices, edges or faces—from the last set of buttons on the window's header. To enter or leave Edit mode, use [Tab].

Out Of The Blue

Finally, here's a hidden feature few know about—if you drag the top menu bar as if you were resizing it, you'll find yourself presented with the information window just above.



Drag down the top menu bar for a surprise!



Use the spacebar to bring up the Add menu

Of all the panels in this information window, the most useful is "View & Controls". Here's where you can decide whether you want to swap the functions of the left and right mouse buttons (some find this more comfortable), change the orbit mode between trackball and turntable (the latter feels a lot more controlled), and a whole bundle of other options.

Help Yourself!

Guiding you through the innards of Blender is going to take a lot more pages than these two, but hopefully, you've shed your inhibitions about its interface. To get the low-down on the program, head over to <http://mediawiki.blender.org> for the manual. Blender's inbuilt help system is quite useful as well, and make sure you go through the shortcut reference—it's refreshing how logically everything is placed.

Enjoy! ■

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